

FIELD OF VISION SHARDA UGRA

Dhoni's New Order



With little fuss, a Test match unobtrusively got underway in Colombo. Since India's last Test visit in 2001, Sri Lanka have lost only two series at home. So, returning victorious would be quite a coup for the Indians.

This is the series that M.S. Dhoni has chosen to miss after an 18-month run of 14 Tests, 56 ODIs, eight Twenty20 internationals and 15 matches in the inaugural IPL. The ODIs include those from two meaningless events in Bangladesh and Pakistan after the IPL. The website Cricinfo calculated that Dhoni had actually been the world's "busiest cricketer", so it was no surprise when he cited burnout and withdrew from the Lanka Tests.

His decision has been termed "bold" and "brave", a breakaway from the Indian cricket's usual hypocrisy of players hanging onto their places in the team. Some take breathers citing injury as an excuse, returning in a short time, remarkably well-repaired, and waving a physio's clean chit. Still, more than any other virtue, Dhoni's is a decision based on supreme confidence in his ability to win his spot back in the Test XI. But is it also, you have to ask, a significant priority-shift?

The free market trumpeters will chorus that this, in fact, is the future. Where the Indian cricketer will turn his back on the long, more complex version of the game and choose to play shorter, more lucrative formats. After all, has not the poster boy of the India's Gen-X cricketer already taken his stand?

But has he? All players involved in the three forms of cricket have privately complained of burnout but, as captain, only Dhoni had the freedom of choice to act on his fatigue. He could have sat out the events just after the IPL but chose to miss the version of the game he has not quite mastered yet. There is no knowing whether Dhoni made his decision based on timing—the Lanka Tests just happened to be the next fixture after he hit a wall—or actual preference. An email to him on the subject went unanswered.

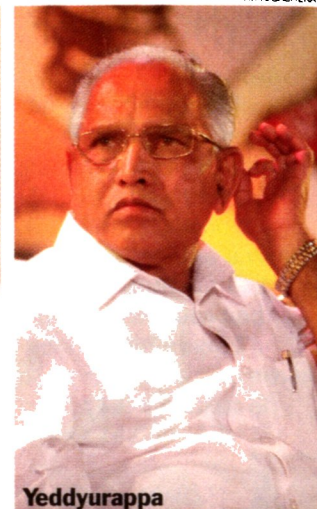
Yes, cricketers must decide what works best for them, their bodies, skills and finances. But they are also custodians of their sport. After their immediate interests are taken care of, players unconsciously fashion the legacy that outlives their careers, that defines who they were. The greatest emerge as pillars, not passengers or pop stars. Dhoni has made a very big call at a time when cricket is churning and custodians are hard to find. From now on, everything he does will tell us what MSD really stands for.



SAURABH SINGH



Patil



Yeddyurappa

It's Raining Politics

BANGALORE Politicians are playing Varuna in Karnataka. Wells are running dry, power-cuts are frequent and Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa, who never loses a chance to brag about his farmer background, has promised cloud seeding for worst affected regions of north Karnataka. The state is already heading towards a near-drought situation.

The abrupt end of pre-monsoon showers, poor rainfall and inclement weather have affected the kharif crop. Early this month, the state received only 21 mm of rain, one-third of the normal rainfall. Only half of the 7.4 lakh hectare of land for oilseeds received rain, while fields of groundnut, sunflower, sesame and even tur dal have got hardly any rainwater.

Quick to make hay while the sun shines, former water resources minister in the Congress Government, H.K. Patil, struck a rapport with farmers. He initiated cloud seeding over areas of Gadag (from where he lost

in the May 2008 Assembly polls), Naragund and Navalgund in north Karnataka through private organisations, K.H. Patil Krishi Vignan Kendra and Agricultural Science Foundation of Hulkoti. Patil scored some brownie points for the 40-minute cloud seeding exercise by a private aviation company and was quick to claim that the district administration had dragged its feet in clearing the programme. "Hubli would have received rains a day earlier," he said.

Hubli is home to five Jnanpeeth awardees and Assembly Speaker Jagadish Shettar, who wanted to be a Cabinet minister. Patil, during his ministership in 2003, experimented with a Rs 5.86-crore cloud seeding programme called Cloud Varuna with a US-based agency. Now, the state Government is also launching its own cloud seeding programmes. Farmers could not have been happier, even if rival politicians are donning the roles of rain makers.

by Stephen David